



Playing CATCH

Bad management, controversies over cash and captaincy—is Indian hockey dying or killing itself? The World Cup in Delhi is now its only chance of survival.



**HOCKEY
WORLD
CUP 2010**

| By Sharda Ugra |

The planet's top nations can go sweat against equals in pre-World Cup training. That is just plain boring. India's Cup countdown had Bollywoody pizzazz. With less than two months to go, there was a sulking furore over the captaincy. With less than six weeks, the players refused to train until their demands for match fees and incentives were met. With less than a month, the team suddenly had two captains, the coach supporting one and the selectors another. With a little over a week for their first Cup match—against Pakistan no less—a handful of players were caught in a mud-flinging

contest with charity match organisers. (Match that, Germany). Officials have accused players of greed. Players say the officials are arrogant. The national coach has been called a politician. Politicians have dived in for publicity. Stadium doors are locked, government and police shift blame like a weak pass on the 25-yard line. The International Hockey Federation (FIH), hoovering in Indian sponsorship money, plays the preening grandee.

Is this farce or tragedy? Or something that belongs to low-brow reality TV rather than sports channels? "Indian hockey is a story of missed opportunities," says Viren Rasquinha, a player. The next fortnight of the World Cup is again one of those chances. This time, to miss it could be fatal. Not only for the 18-strong team at the Cup, but for every stakeholder: officials, bureau-

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